

AP Italian Language & Culture: The Complete Exam Guide

The new project-based exam explained: the presentation and Q&A, the argumentative essay, listening and reading, and 10 practice questions in Italian.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



~2:30 hrs

fully digital exam
in Bluebook

55+3

multiple-choice +
free-response tasks

35%

of your score comes
from your project

69–75%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Your project, plus skills

The exam now centers on a research project you complete during the year about a Italian-speaking community. Your score (1–5) combines speaking about that project, writing, and listening and reading.

20%

Project presentation

15%

Project Q&A

15%

Argumentative e...

50%

Multiple choice • 55 Q

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
Q1 • Project presentation	20% of score 3 min prep + 3 min speaking	Deliver a spoken presentation in Italian answering the project prompt, using your Personalized Project Reference (PPR).
Q2 • Project Q&A	15% of score 4 questions • 40 s each	Answer four pre-recorded questions about your project research.
Q3 • Argumentative essay	15% of score 55 minutes	Write a persuasive essay on a question using three sources with different viewpoints: two print sources and one audio source (heard twice).
II • Multiple choice	50% of score 80 min 55 questions	Listening: 25 questions (40 min, 25%) on audio sources • Reading: 30 questions (40 min, 25%) on print texts.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

BEFORE EXAM DAY

Submit your PPR by late April

Your **Personalized Project Reference** is a structured outline of your research and sources. Submit it in the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline; you can see it during the presentation.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 15 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.

SECTION II

02 Listening & reading

55 questions in about 80 minutes. Listening questions use authentic audio such as interviews, podcasts and announcements; reading questions use articles, ads, charts and literary texts.

25

listening questions on audio sources

30

reading questions on print sources

50%

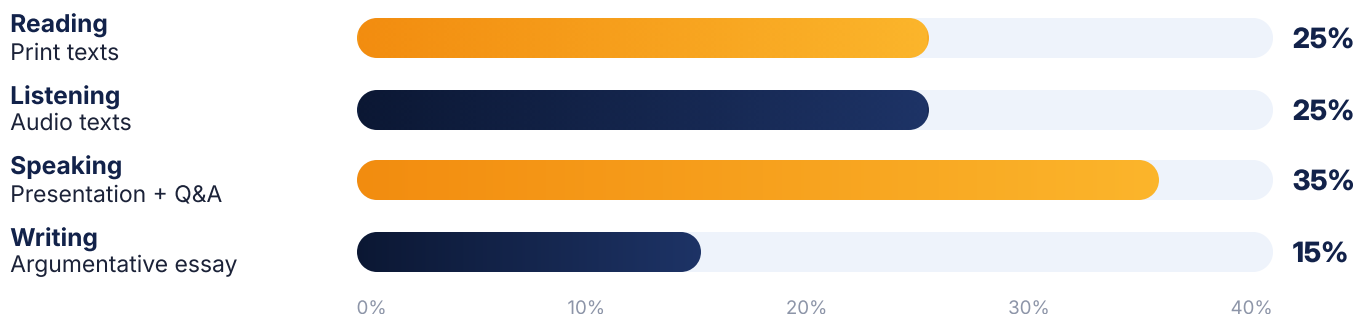
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How your score is built

Share of the total exam score for each skill.

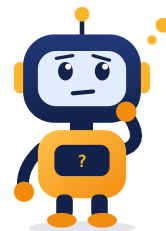


What this means for your study time: Speaking about your project is the single biggest part of the exam (35%). Listening and reading together are half, so daily exposure to authentic audio and texts matters.

Strategies that work on this section

- Preview the questions before each audio plays, so you know what to listen for.
- Take short notes while listening: names, numbers, opinions and the main idea.
- Read the introduction line of each text; it tells you the source and purpose.
- Don't translate word for word. Use context to infer meaning of unknown words.
- Watch for paraphrase. Correct answers rarely repeat the text's exact words.
- Never leave a blank. There is no penalty for guessing.

Listen to **Italian podcasts or news** for 10 minutes a day. It trains your ear for natural speed.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 6 themes & the project

Course content is organized into six themes. Your project connects research to one of them, using authentic sources in Italian.

THEME

1

Families & Communities

Explore: family values, traditions and how communities are changing in Italian-speaking communities.

THEME

2

Language & Culture

Explore: how language, media and technology shape identity and cultural expression.

THEME

3

Art & Creativity

Explore: how art, music and literature reflect a community's history and values.

THEME

4

Science & Technology

Explore: how scientific and technological change affects daily life and society.

THEME

5

Contemporary Life

Explore: education, work, leisure, popular culture and changing lifestyles.

THEME

6

Global Contexts

Explore: how global issues such as the environment, migration and health affect communities.

◆ The course project, step by step

1 • Research

Investigate the project prompt using authentic Italian-language sources.

2 • Build your PPR

Create your Personalized Project Reference: a structured outline of findings and sources.

3 • Submit

Upload the PPR to the AP Digital Portfolio by the late-April deadline.

4 • Present

On exam day, present for 3 minutes and answer 4 questions about your research.

SECTION I

04 The free-response tasks

Two spoken tasks about your project, then one argumentative essay.

Presentation · 20%

Q&A · 15%

Essay · 15%

Free response = 50% of your AP score

Q1

Project presentation

3 min prep · 3 min speaking

Answer the project prompt using what you learned. Organize clearly: introduction, main findings with examples from your sources, and a conclusion.

Practice timing: aim for 2:45–3:00 so you use the full time.

Q2

Project Q&A

4 questions · 40 seconds each

Respond to four recorded questions that ask you to explain, extend or reflect on your research.

Answer directly in the first sentence, then add one detail or example.

Q3

Argumentative essay

55 minutes

Read two print sources, listen to an audio source twice, then write a persuasive essay that takes a position and cites all three sources.

State your thesis in the first paragraph and cite each source by number.

Tip

Using sources well

Essay success

Synthesize the sources: compare viewpoints, use them as evidence, and explain how each supports your position.

Don't just summarize each source in turn.

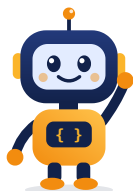
● Presentation: your 6 minutes

Review PPR
1 min

Plan points
2 min

Present
3 min

Use the preparation time to choose two or three key findings and an example for each.



Use **linking words** and a range of tenses. Variety in your speaking raises your score.

FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

05

Anatomy of a strong presentation

Here is a short sample of a strong project presentation opening, annotated to show what earns points.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (project presentation style): How are young people helping small Italian communities face population decline? Use what you learned in your research.

Sample presentation opening

- ① Oggi vorrei spiegare come alcuni giovani aiutano i piccoli paesi italiani ad affrontare lo spopolamento.
- ② Secondo un articolo che ho letto, a Borgo San Pietro una biblioteca digitale ha attirato cinque nuove famiglie in due anni.
- ③ Inoltre, i corsi di informatica per gli anziani creano un legame tra le generazioni.
- ④ Per questo, penso che questi progetti mostrino quanto gli italiani tengano alle proprie radici locali.

- ① **Clear introduction** that answers the prompt.
- ② **Specific finding** with an example from a source.
- ③ **Connectors** that organize ideas.
- ④ **Cultural insight** beyond simple facts.

Five habits for every speaking and writing task

1

Answer the question in your first sentence.

2

Use connectors to organize ideas.

3

Vary tenses and sentence structures.

4

Self-correct briefly, then keep going.

5

Use every second of speaking time.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Just **memorize** your presentation! (Careful.)



01 A memorized script

The presentation should sound natural. Know your findings well rather than reciting word for word.

02 Missing the PPR deadline

Without a submitted Personalized Project Reference, you won't have your outline during the presentation.

03 Too short

Stopping at 1:30 of a 3-minute presentation limits your score. Use the full time.

04 Ignoring the Q&A question

Answer exactly what is asked first; then elaborate.

05 Long silences

Use fillers in Italian and keep going rather than stopping.

06 Only one tense

Showing past, present and future tenses demonstrates range.

07 Word-for-word translation

Think in phrases, not single words, to avoid unnatural sentences.

08 Summarizing sources

Use sources as evidence for your position rather than summarizing them.

09 Skipping notes while listening

Brief notes on names, numbers and opinions make audio questions much easier.

10 Cultural facts without insight

Explain what a practice or product shows about a community's perspectives.

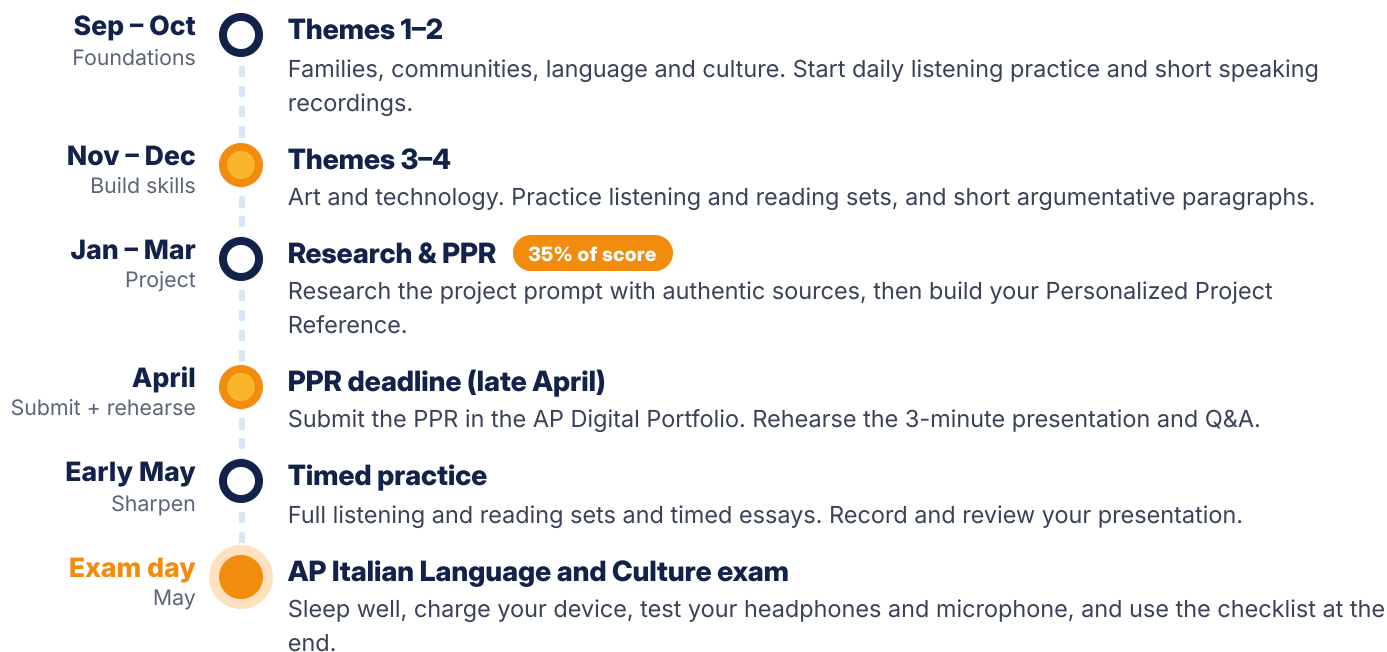
Quick self-check: can you speak about your project topic in Italian for three minutes using *passato prossimo*, *imperfetto*, *presente* and *futuro*, plus connectors such as *inoltre*, *però*, *per questo*?

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Schedule your project research early so the PPR is ready well before the late-April deadline.



◆ The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: one listening and one reading set	Name your weaker skill
3 weeks out	Daily: 10 min listening, one recorded presentation run	Use the full 3 minutes
2 weeks out	Full practice exam under timing	Finish every task
Final week	Light review: PPR, connectors, Q&A practice	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original reading and language questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Explanations on the answer page are in English. Give yourself **15 minutes**, then check page 11.

1 LETTURA • IDEA PRINCIPALE

Leggi il testo e rispondi alle domande 1–4.

In molti piccoli paesi italiani, la popolazione sta diminuendo perché i giovani si trasferiscono nelle grandi città. A Borgo San Pietro, però, un gruppo di ragazzi ha deciso di restare e di aprire una biblioteca digitale nella vecchia scuola del paese. «Vogliamo dimostrare che anche qui si può costruire un futuro», racconta Giulia, una delle fondatrici. La biblioteca offre corsi di informatica per gli anziani e uno spazio di lavoro condiviso per chi lavora a distanza. In due anni, cinque famiglie si sono trasferite nel paese.

Testo originale scritto da ACT SAT GO per esercitazione

Qual è l'idea principale del testo?

- A I giovani italiani preferiscono le grandi città.
- B La vecchia scuola è stata demolita.
- C Un gruppo di giovani cerca di dare un futuro al proprio paese con una biblioteca digitale.
- D Gli anziani non vogliono imparare l'informatica.

2 LETTURA • DETTAGLIO

Che cosa offre la biblioteca, secondo il testo?

- A Corsi di informatica per anziani e uno spazio di lavoro condiviso
- B Solo libri antichi
- C Un ristorante
- D Lezioni di cucina

3 LETTURA • INFERENZA

Il trasferimento di cinque famiglie suggerisce che il progetto:

- A non ha avuto effetti
- B ha fatto aumentare i prezzi
- C ha chiuso la scuola
- D sta aiutando a contrastare lo spopolamento

4 LETTURA • LESSICO

Nel testo, "lavora a distanza" significa:

- A lavora all'estero
- B lavora da casa o da remoto
- C lavora in fabbrica
- D non lavora

5 GRAMMATICA • CONGIUNTIVO

Completa: "Penso che il progetto ____ molto utile."

- A è
- B sarà
- C era
- D sia

08 TEST YOURSELF (continued)

6 GRAMMATICA • PASSATO

Completa: "Da bambina, Giulia ___ spesso in biblioteca, ma l'anno scorso ___ un corso nuovo."

- A è andata / apriva
- B andrà / aprirà
- C andava / ha aperto
- D va / apre

7 CONNETTIVI

Quale connettivo esprime un contrasto? "Il paese è piccolo; ___, offre molte opportunità."

- A tuttavia
- B quindi
- C inoltre
- D per esempio

8 REGISTRO

Quale saluto è più adatto per un'email formale al sindaco?

- A Ciao!
- B Gentile Signor Sindaco,
- C Ehi, come va?
- D Caro amico,

9 GRAMMATICA • CONDIZIONALE

Completa: "Se avessi tempo, ___ come volontario in biblioteca."

- A lavoro
- B lavorerò
- C lavorerei
- D lavoravo

10 CULTURA • PROSPETTIVA

Quale frase esprime meglio una prospettiva culturale?

- A La biblioteca apre alle nove.
- B La scuola ha tre piani.
- C Il paese ha una piazza.
- D Molti italiani sentono un forte legame con il proprio paese d'origine, anche se vivono altrove.

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	C	The text describes young people opening a digital library to give their village a future.
2	A	The library offers computer classes for older people and a shared workspace for remote workers.
3	D	New families moving in suggests the project is helping counter population decline.
4	B	"Lavorare a distanza" means working remotely.
5	D - sia	"Penso che" expresses opinion and requires the congiuntivo: sia.
6	C - andava / ha aperto	A repeated past habit takes the imperfetto; a completed action last year takes the passato prossimo.
7	A - tuttavia	"Tuttavia" (however) introduces a contrast.
8	B	"Gentile Signor Sindaco," is the appropriate formal greeting.
9	C - lavorerei	A hypothetical "se" clause with the congiuntivo imperfetto takes the condizionale.
10	D	A perspective explains values and attitudes, such as attachment to one's home town, not just facts.

9-10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6-8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0-5

Build foundations now. Read and listen to Italian every day, and practice speaking for three minutes without stopping.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 69–75% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Italian Language and Culture, and about 19–25% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

69–75%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

19–25%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Your **PPR was submitted** in the AP Digital Portfolio before the late-April deadline
- ☐ **Headphones and microphone** tested for the speaking and listening sections
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review your PPR and practice the presentation once the night before

In the free-response tasks: answer every prompt directly, organize ideas with connectors, show a range of vocabulary and tenses, use the full time, and explain cultural perspectives, not just facts.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

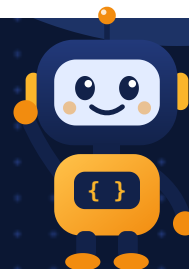
Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Italian plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

Book a free diagnostic lesson →



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Italian conversation practice

Live 1-on-1 speaking sessions to build fluency for the presentation and Q&A.

Project & writing skills

Argumentative essay coaching and research-skills support. Your project stays 100% your own work.

Listening & reading practice

Timed sets with authentic audio and texts, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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